

## Manx shearwater

On dark nights, the wails and screams of shearwaters returning to their nesting burrows sound spooky. They gather in huge groups called “rafts” near the coast, waiting for darkness before coming in to land. This helps them avoid attack by enemies, especially great black-backed gulls.

0 100 200 300 km  
0 100 200 miles



Stiff, straight wings allow it to glide close to the water.

**Manx shearwater**  
(*Puffinus puffinus*)  
Length: 1 ft 3 in (38 cm)

## SAFETY IN NUMBERS

More than 95 percent of the world’s seabirds, such as these puffins, nest in large groups called colonies. Predators are less likely to attack a colony, which contains thousands of birds, so the birds’ eggs and young have a better chance of survival. The birds in the colony also warn each other of approaching danger. Some birds fly off the nest to attack an enemy; others sit on their nests and make a lot of noise.



Gannets breed in vast colonies of more than 200,000 pairs. They usually remain faithful to one partner.

**Northern gannet**  
(*Morus bassanus*)  
Length: 3 ft 3 in (1 m)

Streamlined body shape enables gannets to dive like a torpedo into the sea.

Sharp edges on the top bill and spines on the tongue help hold up to 50 small fish at a time.

**Atlantic puffin**  
(*Fratercula arctica*)  
Length: 1 ft 2 in (36 cm)

The webbed feet spread out like brakes to slow the puffin down as it comes in to land.

## Northern gannet

To catch fish, the gannet makes spectacular dives into the sea, often from great heights. Its strong skull helps it withstand the impact of hitting the water and its nostrils can be closed off underwater. It uses its stout bill to grasp prey, such as fish and squid, and drag it to the surface. During the breeding season, the birds nest very close together. After about 14 weeks on the nest, the chicks head out to sea. They do not develop their final adult colors for five to six years.

## Atlantic puffin

The puffin feeds on fish that it catches underwater. It has webbed feet and small wings, which it uses like fins to propel itself through the water. In the breeding season, the puffin develops a larger, more powerful bill to attract a mate. The bill is also used to dig a nesting burrow in a grassy cliff-top. When it has grown its feathers, the young puffin leaves its burrow under cover of darkness to avoid predators.